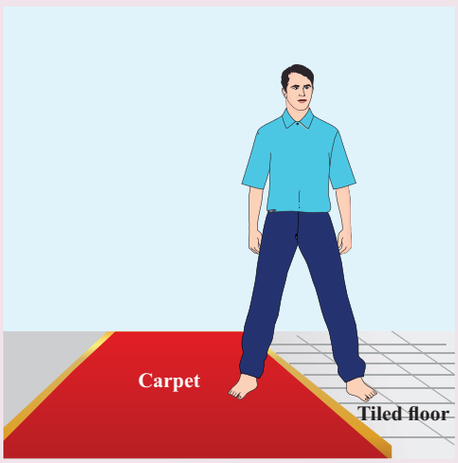
thermal equilibrium with other systems or not. Zeroth law enables us to determine the temperature. For example, when a thermometer is kept in contact with a human body, it reaches thermal equilibrium with the body. At this condition, the temperature of the thermometer will be same as the human body. This principle is used in finding the body temperature.

Activity

We often associate the temperature as a measure of how hot or cold an object is while touching it. Can we use our sensory organs to determine the temperature of an object?

When you stand bare feet with one foot on the carpet and the other on the tiled floor, your foot on tiled floor feels cooler than the foot on the carpet even though both the tiled floor and carpet are at the same room temperature. It is because the tiled floor transfers the heat energy to your skin at higher rate than the carpet. So the skin is not measuring the actual temperature of the object; instead it measures the rate of heat energy transfer. But if we place a thermometer on the tiled floor or carpet it will show the same temperature.



8.6 INTERNAL ENERGY (U)

The internal energy of a thermodynamic system is the sum of kinetic and potential energies of all the molecules of the system with respect to the center of mass of the system.

The energy due to molecular motion including translational, rotational and vibrational motion is called internal kinetic energy (E_K)

The energy due to molecular interaction is called internal potential energy (E_p). Example: Bond energy.

$$U = E_K + E_P$$

- Since ideal gas molecules are assumed to have no interaction with each other the internal energy consists of only kinetic energy part (E_K) which depends on the temperature, number of particles and is independent of volume. However this is not true for real gases like Van der Waals gases.
- Internal energy is a state variable. It depends only on the initial and final states of the thermodynamic system. For example, if the temperature of water is raised from 30°C to 40°C either by heating or by stirring, the final internal energy depends only on the final temperature 40°C and not the way it is arrived at.

Note

It is very important to note that the internal energy of a thermodynamic system is associated with only the kinetic energy of the individual molecule due to its random motion and the potential energy of molecules which depends on their chemical nature. The bulk kinetic energy of the entire system or gravitational potential energy of the system should not be mistaken as a part of internal energy. For example

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